Christian influence even though the scientists reject Christianity. AI advocates are not Christian, but their version of technological salvation is just like Christian salvation, except where computers replace god. In the 1970s, AI cheerleaders in the US started predicting that the world would transform from a place of biological life into a place of machine life and that human beings would become immortal by uploading our minds into robot bodies. This view of cosmic meaning and human immortality borrows directly from American religious life and creates a new form of scientific religion. Its believers tell us that a new world is underway.

Indians now hear such ideas, especially through streaming media, and these ideas run into a public culture suffused with religious practices and beliefs. Meanwhile, there is not always a clear distinction between religion and science in India. Hindu scientists will tell you that everything is compartmentalised and kept distinct, but then celebrate auspicious pujas and holidays in their laboratories. Not all Indians are Hindu, but Hinduism has always been part of how many Indians adopt new technologies.

Until recently, there hasn't been much attention given to AI in technical circles, but every appearance of AI in religious circles causes waves. Animatronic gods at Hindu temples have served as a source of wonder that excites religious feelings, so it's probably no surprise that many everyday people and even ascetic sadhus now think that Vishnu could return to earth as a robotic Kalki. In Hinduism, the integration of new technologies is as old as Ayudha Puja and Vishwakarma Puja, both festivals that take the technologies of their users and place them squarely into the religious practice of the community. So of course it was inevitable that we would see robotic arms performing arti and GPT clones for gods like Krishna. It will be interesting to see whether "gods" talking through AI will change festivals where gods talk through human mediums (e.g. the Theyyam dances of Kerala).

TAKEAWAYS

- **AI hype and disappointment has a long cultural history in the US, but not in India**
- **The debate over AI ethics is still too small in the US and it is desperately so in India**
- **We look to technology for answers, so AI deepfakes as well as hallucinations could have disastrous consequences**

IN THE US, TECH CULTURE **IS ATHEIST BUT REPLICATES** CHRISTIAN PATTERNS. **INDIA HAS A MORE OPEN RELIGIOSITY**

In the US, tech culture is decidedly atheist, meaning that in tech circles there is little competition for apocalyptic dreams about superintelligent AI gods and immortal minds. Belief in those things is the only religion in the marketplace. No other stories are being told about AI. And so belief in these has become commonplace not just among the tech crowd but in the pop culture that draws on tech culture. In India, those beliefs are on the rise—a rise no doubt accelerated by the everyday visibility of generative AI projects like GPT and DALL-E. But those beliefs also run into many common forms of integrating technology with traditional Hindu beliefs and practices. So, there are more different possibilities for interpreting AI in Indian tech culture, and thus also in Indian pop culture.

The religious views will always mix with other public concerns. For example, AI fuels the problem of viral misinformation. WhatsApp is a playground for fabricated nonsense purporting to be news about real people, usually designed to create political conflict. The lies that circulate so readily on WhatsApp do so because people are too often prepared to believe the things they read (especially if those things align with what they already want to believe). And now generative AI "hallucinates" facts and deepfake technologies allow for the deliberate construction of videos of that lie. Politicians can appear to say terrible things, which is just one example of how dangerous deepfake videos can be for the public. But while deepfakes are deliberate, the accidental outcomes of ChatGPT and similar AI models hallucinating could have equally disastrous results. We look to these technologies to be "right" and when they definitively offer answers, we tend to follow blindly along. These concerns exist across the world, including both in the US and India, though in the former, a more robust conversation is happening around them.

The debate over AI ethics is still too small in the US and it is desperately so in India. It is important that we harness all of our cultural resources to think about how we can use AI to benefit humanity: how will it ease our burdens, improve our democracy and drive us toward a more fair and just world? What will be the story of integrating AI into human life? ■